FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

All elections are important, but some assume greater significance than others. The Karnataka election on May 10 will be one such. Like the 'butterfly effect' in ecology, where the slight disturbance of air caused by one delicate pair of flapping wings in one corner of the world can cause a storm halfway across the planet, the poll outcome in Karnataka can influence national political events in a major way.

For one, it inaugurates a series of five big 'semi-final' elections in 2023. Victory in the state will grant the BJP government at the Centre positive momentum before the 2024 general election. Karnataka will be followed by Telangana seven months later—at the sub-national level, whether it retains or loses its lone fortress in the South will send out a psychologically vital signal. And the BJP is banking on a southern push to set off any attrition in its northern citadels, where it has maxed out its potential. For the Congress, whose footprint presently stands whittled down to three states that it rules on its own—Rajasthan, Chhattisgarh and Himachal Pradesh—it's a 'must win' situation. Karnataka is one of the states where it faces off directly against the BJP, a pattern that will be replicated in Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh when these states go to the polls this winter. So, to bolster its claim of being the main Opposition alternative to the Narendra Modi dispensation, it cannot afford to let slip the slight edge it is stated to have in Karnataka.

The BJP goes into this election with anti-incumbency sentiment weighing it down, and under a chief minister who's not exactly a mass leader with a devoted populace. Basavaraj Bommai got his chair only in July 2021, after the BJP decided to replace B.S. Yediyurappa mid-way through his tenure, and has held on to it since against some heavy odds. He may be in line for a second tenure if the BJP scrapes through, but his ability to play a vote-swinging role has yet to be proven. With burning issues such as corruption, inflation and unemployment, which the Opposition has so vociferously raised, the challenges that he and the BJP face to retain Karnataka are truly daunting.

The Congress, on the other hand, is playing on turf where it has strong ground presence. Its vote share has never dipped much below 35 per cent since 1999. Indeed, it had 38.04 per cent in the assembly poll in 2018—a rise of 1.4 percentage points—even though distorted distribution meant it lost its majority and fell to 80 seats. Moreover, it has a big mass leader with proven administrative capacities in Siddaramaiah, and a modicum of operational unity with his intra-party rival, the moneyed state chief D.K. Shivakumar who knows how to manage the party flock. And unlike the BJP, its vote base is universalist in nature: it harvests from the entire swathe of 33 per cent OBCs, 24 per cent scheduled castes and tribes, 13 per cent Muslims, and also has a share of the 17 per cent Lingayat and 12 per cent Vokkaliga vote. It is hoping that anti-incumbency and governance issues will help it regain power in the state.



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The BJP is hoping that its four-fold strategy pays off. This is built around a major initiative on caste reservation laid on top of its religion-based narrative, a slew of welfare promises to add to the beneficiaries of central schemes, shedding anti-incumbency by bringing in fresh faces in over a third of the total constituencies, and the X-factor that is Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who will be literally camping in the state for the final haul.

The saffron party has never won a majority in Karnataka on its own—the maximum it has touched is 110, three less than what is needed for a simple majority in the 224-seat assembly. To better that, the BJP needs to grow beyond its dependence on the powerful Lingayat community. So, just before the elections were announced, the Bommai government ingeniously blended caste politics with religion by scrapping OBC reservations for Muslims and redistributing the freed-up 4 per cent quota equally among the Lingayats and Vokkaligas, the other dominant caste group. Though on hold because of a case in the Supreme Court, the intended message has gone out. Second, in October 2022, the BJP government promulgated an ordinance to increase reservations for SCs by 2 per cent and for STs by 4 per cent in the state, further apportioning the new total of 17 per cent SC quota among the constituent castes in a way it hopes will give good returns. How the BJP quota gambits play out will be critical for it this time.

The unknown quantity is H.D. Kumaraswamy's Janata Dal (Secular) or JD(S), which has settled down into the role of a third force in the state. The party's usual strike rate of 30-40 seats can only come at the expense of the Congress, especially in the crucial 67-seat Old Mysuru region. If neither the BJP nor the Congress are able to secure a majority on their own, the JD(S) could become the kingmaker and Kumaraswamy the king, as has happened twice in the past. Leveraging the limited seats that the JD(S) won, he became chief minister in 2006 and, more recently, in 2018, by joining hands with either of the dominant parties to form a post-poll coalition. Neither tenure lasted even two years, but that doesn't eliminate him as a key player on the landscape. To understand the major factors that could determine the outcome of the Karnataka polls, Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa, along with Associate Editor Ajay Sukumaran, mined the ground and spoke to key leaders for this week's cover story, 'The Fierce Battle'. With voting due on May 10, the last two weeks of the campaign would prove decisive. Even psephologists are chary of predicting the outcome. It is a close and fierce fight. One has to wait till May 13 to see which way the butterfly wings will flap.



(Aroon Purie)